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MCP server

An **MCP server** (Model Context Protocol server) is a standardized backend service that exposes tools, data sources, and prompts to AI agents (like Claude, GitHub Copilot, or custom LLM applications) through a universal interface. Think of it as a **“USB-C port for AI”**—a single, consistent way for AI models to discover and interact with external systems without custom integrations for each tool.

What Is an MCP Server?

An MCP server implements the Model Context Protocol (MCP), an open standard introduced by Anthropic in late 2024. It acts as a bridge between

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AI clients and real-world systems—such as databases, APIs, file systems, or SaaS platforms—allowing LLMs to securely query data, trigger actions, or retrieve context in real time.

Unlike traditional APIs, MCP servers support **automatic tool discovery**, **structured JSON-RPC 2.0 communication**, and **dynamic orchestration**, making them ideal for agentic AI workflows.

Core Architecture

MCP follows a clean client-server model:

- **MCP Client**: Embedded in AI applications (e.g., Claude Desktop, Cursor, GitHub Copilot). It initiates

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connections and requests tools.

- **MCP Server**: Hosts one or more tools (e.g., “list GitHub pull requests” or “query Salesforce”). It advertises available capabilities and executes requests.
- **Transport**: Communication occurs via **stdio** (for local tools) or **HTTP with Server-Sent Events (SSE)** (for remote services).

The server responds to three key request types:

1. **Tool discovery**: Lists available functions with schemas.
2. **Tool invocation**: Executes a specific tool with provided arguments.
3. **Resource/prompt access**: Retrieves files, documentation, or templated interactions.

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MCP Server vs. Traditional APIs

Feature	MCP Server	Traditional REST/GraphQL API
---------	------------	------------------------------

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Purpose	Built for AI agents to dynamically discover and use tools	General-purpose data access
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Tool Discovery	Automatic via protocol handshake	Manual endpoint documentation
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Authentication	Centralized, per-agent policies	Per-service tokens or OAuth
-----------------------	---------------------------------	-----------------------------

Workflow Support	Native multi-step orchestration	Stateless request-response
-------------------------	---------------------------------	----------------------------

Error Handling	Structured feedback for LLM correction	Generic HTTP status codes
-----------------------	--	---------------------------

Reusability	One server works with any MCP	
--------------------	-------------------------------	--

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client | Often requires client-specific adapters |

Real-World Examples

Several major platforms now offer official MCP servers:

- **GitHub MCP Server**: Lets AI agents read repos, manage issues, and analyze code via natural language.
- **AWS MCP Server**: Provides secure, authenticated access to all AWS services for coding assistants.
- **Microsoft Learn MCP Server**: Feeds up-to-date documentation into AI agents like GitHub Copilot.
- **Atlassian MCP Server**: Connects agents to

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Jira, Confluence, and Opsgenie.

- **Community Servers**: Over 9,800 servers exist for databases (PostgreSQL, Supabase), browsers (Browserbase), design tools (Blender), and more.

Why MCP Servers Matter

MCP servers solve critical AI integration challenges:

- **Eliminate brittle integrations**: No more custom code for every new data source.
- **Reduce hallucinations**: Ground LLMs in real-time, verified data.
- **Enhance security**: Enforce access controls and data masking at the server level.
- **Enable composability**: Combine multiple servers (e.g., GitHub + Slack + Calendar) for

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complex agent workflows.

As AI agents evolve from chatbots to autonomous workers, MCP servers provide the standardized “toolbelt” they need to act reliably in the real world.

In the Model Context Protocol (MCP), a **schema** is a formal **JSON Schema** definition that describes the structure, data types, and constraints for tool inputs and outputs. It acts as a strict contract between the AI client and the MCP server, ensuring that the AI model provides valid arguments and can correctly interpret the results.

Core Components of an MCP Schema

Every MCP tool definition relies on two primary

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schema objects:

1. Input Schema (`inputSchema`)

The **`inputSchema`** is a **required** field that defines the parameters a tool accepts. It tells the AI model exactly what data is needed to execute a function.

- **Structure**: It must be a valid JSON Schema object where the root `type` is almost always `"object"`.
- **Properties**: It lists available arguments (e.g., `location`, `query`), their data types (`string`, `number`, `boolean`), and descriptions to guide the model's reasoning.
- **Validation**: The `required` array specifies which fields are mandatory, preventing the model from hallucinating or omitting critical data.

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2. Output Schema (`outputSchema`)

The **`outputSchema`** is an **optional** field (introduced in later specifications) that defines the structure of the data the tool will return.

- **Purpose**: It enables **structured content**, allowing the server to return machine-readable JSON alongside human-readable text.
- **Validation**: If defined, the server **must** return a **`structuredContent`** object that strictly conforms to this schema. This allows clients to programmatically parse results (e.g., extracting a specific temperature value) without relying on text parsing.

Schema Specification Standards

MCP schemas adhere to the **JSON Schema**

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2020-12** standard by default.

- **Default Dialect**: If a schema does not explicitly specify a `$schema` field, MCP implementations assume JSON Schema 2020-12.

- **Advanced Features**: Modern MCP specifications (e.g., the 2026-07-28 release) support advanced JSON Schema features like composition (`oneOf`, `anyOf`), conditionals, and references (`$ref`), allowing for complex, nested data structures.

Practical Example

Below is a complete tool definition for a weather service, illustrating both input and output schemas:

```
```json
```

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```
{
 "name": "get_weather_data",
 "description": "Retrieves current weather
conditions for a specific location.",
 "inputSchema": {
 "type": "object",
 "properties": {
 "location": {
 "type": "string",
 "description": "City name or zip code"
 },
 "units": {
 "type": "string",
 "enum": ["celsius", "fahrenheit"],
 "default": "celsius",
 "description": "Temperature unit preference"
 }
 }
 }
}
```

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```
{
 "required": ["location"]
},
"outputSchema": {
 "type": "object",
 "properties": {
 "temperature": { "type": "number" },
 "conditions": { "type": "string" },
 "humidity": { "type": "number" }
 },
 "required": ["temperature", "conditions",
 "humidity"]
}
}
```

In this example, the AI knows it *must* provide a

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`location` but can optionally specify `units`. Upon execution, it expects a structured JSON response containing `temperature`, `conditions`, and `humidity`, ensuring reliable data handling for downstream tasks.op

An **MCP server prototype** is a minimal, functional implementation used to test tools, resources, and prompts before production deployment. The fastest way to prototype is using the **FastMCP** library in Python, which abstracts complex JSON-RPC handling into simple decorators.

## **## Minimal Python Prototype**

This "Hello World" prototype creates a server with

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one tool and one dynamic resource in under 15 lines of code. It uses the **\*\*stdio\*\*** transport, making it ideal for local testing with CLI clients like ``claude`` or ``cursor``.

```
```python
from mcp.server.fastmcp import FastMCP

# 1. Initialize the server
mcp = FastMCP("Prototype Server")

# 2. Define a Tool (Action)
@mcp.tool()
def add(a: int, b: int) -> int:
    """Add two numbers together."""
    return a + b
```

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3. Define a Resource (Data)

```
@mcp.resource("greeting://{name}")
def greet(name: str) -> str:
    """Generate a personalized greeting."""
    return f"Hello, {name}!"
```

4. Run the server

```
if __name__ == "__main__":
    mcp.run(transport="stdio")
    ...
```

Running and Testing the Prototype

To test this prototype locally:

1. ****Install Dependencies****:

```
```bash
```

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```
pip install mcp
...
```

## 2. **\*\*Run the Server\*\***:

Save the code as `server.py` and execute it. It will wait for input on `stdin`.

```
```bash
python server.py
...
```

3. ****Connect a Client****:

Use the MCP Inspector or a compatible client (like Claude Desktop) configured to run `python server.py` as a local command. The client will automatically discover the `add` tool and `greeting` resource.

Advanced Prototype: HTTP Transport

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For remote testing or web-based clients, switch the transport to ****HTTP (SSE)****. This requires a web framework like ``Starlette`` or ``FastAPI``.

```
` `` `python
```

```
from mcp.server.fastmcp import FastMCP
from starlette.applications import Starlette
from starlette.routing import Route
from starlette.responses import JSONResponse
from starlette.requests import Request
```

```
mcp = FastMCP("Remote Prototype")
```

```
@mcp.tool()
```

```
def multiply(a: int, b: int) -> int:
```

```
    """Multiply two numbers."""
```

```
    return a * b
```

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```
async def handle_mcp(request: Request):  
    payload = await request.json()  
    result = await mcp.handle_http(payload)  
    return JSONResponse(result)
```

```
app = Starlette(routes=[Route("/mcp",  
    endpoint=handle_mcp, methods=["POST"])]])
```

```
if __name__ == "__main__":  
    import uvicorn  
    uvicorn.run(app, host="0.0.0.0", port=8000)  
    ...
```

Production-Ready Templates

For complex prototypes requiring database connections, authentication, or Docker support,

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use established GitHub templates rather than starting from scratch:

Python (FastMCP): The

[`redhat-data-and-ai/template-mcp-server`](https://github.com/redhat-data-and-ai/template-mcp-server) includes OAuth, structured logging, and health checks.

TypeScript: The

[`mclenhard/mcp-server-template`](https://github.com/mclenhard/mcp-server-template) offers robust stateless HTTP and stateful stdio support with full type safety.

Cookiecutter: The

[`ntk148v/mcp-server-template`](https://github.com/ntk148v/mcp-server-template) generates a complete project structure via CLI prompt.

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The core **features** of an MCP server are organized into three primary primitives exposed by the server, plus advanced client-facing capabilities for agentic workflows. As of the latest **2026-07-28 specification**, note that **Sampling** and **Roots** are deprecated in favor of Multi Round-Trip Requests (MRTR).

Core Server Primitives

These are the fundamental building blocks any MCP server exposes:

1. Tools (Model-Controlled Actions)

Tools are executable functions that the AI model can discover and invoke to perform actions with side effects.

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- **Purpose**: Enable the AI to *do* things (e.g., write files, query databases, send emails, trigger CI/CD pipelines).
- **Control**: The **LLM decides** when to call them based on user intent.
- **Structure**: Defined by a ``name``, ``description``, and a strict JSON ``inputSchema``.
- **Example**: ``create_jira_ticket``, ``search_database``, ``send_slack_message``.

2. Resources (Read-Only Context)

Resources are passive, read-only data sources that provide context to the AI or user.

- **Purpose**: Ground the AI in real-time data without allowing modification (e.g., file contents, API responses, documentation, logs).
- **Control**: The **Host Application** or User

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typically triggers access, though the AI can request them.

- **Structure**: Identified by a unique URI (e.g., `file://`, `postgres://`, `https://`).
- **Example**: `file:///var/log/app.log`,
`github://repo/issues`,
`salesforce://account/123`.

3. Prompts (Reusable Templates)

Prompts are pre-built, parameterized instruction templates that guide the AI's behavior for specific workflows.

- **Purpose**: Standardize complex interactions and encode domain expertise (often surfaced as slash commands like `/debug` or `/summarize`).
- **Control**: The **User** typically triggers them, often selecting from a menu.

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- **Structure**: Can include static text, dynamic arguments, and embedded resource content.
- **Example**: "Analyze this code for security vulnerabilities," "Draft a reply to this email thread."

Advanced & Deprecated Features

The protocol previously included client-side features to support complex agentic behaviors, but these are evolving rapidly in 2026.

Feature	Status (Aug 2026)	Function
---------	-------------------	----------

:	:	:
---	---	---

Elicitation	 Active	Allows the server to request specific information or confirmation from the user (e.g., "Which airport do you prefer?").
--------------------	---	--

Sampling	 Deprecated	Was: Allowed
-----------------	---	---------------------

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servers to request LLM completions from the client.

Now: Replaced by direct LLM API integration or MRTR. I

I ****Roots**** I  ****Deprecated**** I ***Was:*** Defined filesystem boundaries for the server. ***Now:*** Handled via explicit scope configuration. I

I ****Logging**** I  ****Deprecated**** I ***Was:*** Standardized server log messages. ***Now:*** Handled via standard transport logs. I

I ****MRTR**** I  ****New**** I ****Multi Round-Trip Requests****: The modern replacement for Sampling/Roots, enabling stateless, complex handshakes. I

Security & Transport Features

Beyond functional primitives, MCP includes critical

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infrastructure features:

- **OAuth 2.1 Authentication**: Mandatory for remote HTTP servers. Supports PKCE, dynamic client registration, and scoped tokens to prevent "confused deputy" attacks.
- **Dual Transport Support**:
 - **stdio**: For local, single-user processes (secure by isolation).
 - **Streamable HTTP (SSE)**: For remote, multi-client servers over HTTPS.
- **Dynamic Discovery**: Clients automatically detect available tools/resources via `tools/list` and `resources/list` without hardcoding endpoints.
- **Structured Content**: Supports returning strictly typed JSON (`outputSchema`) alongside

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human-readable text for reliable programmatic parsing.

MCP server use cases span from individual developer productivity tools to enterprise-wide agentic workflows, with **software development**, **data analysis**, and **regulated industry compliance** being the highest-adoption areas as of August 2026.

Primary Use Case Categories

1. AI-Assisted Software Development (Highest Volume)

This is the dominant use case, with **86,000+ MCP servers** deployed primarily for coding workflows.

- **Repository Management**: AI agents use the

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GitHub MCP Server to create PRs spanning multiple repos, analyze code diffs, trigger CI/CD pipelines, and search release history without leaving the IDE.

- **Interactive Debugging**: Agents connect to Linear, Jira, Sentry, and Statsig to verify feature implementations, inspect production logs, and correlate errors with recent deployments.
- **Legacy System Integration**: Engineers build custom MCP servers to expose data from complex ALM tools (e.g., **Siemens Polarion**) for aircraft requirement tracking, allowing AI to surface documents that previously required specialized skills.
- **Browser Automation**: Frontend developers use **Playwright** and **Puppeteer MCP servers** to interact with UIs via accessibility trees, automate screenshot capture for PR descriptions,

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and record screen flows for review.

2. Enterprise Data Access & Knowledge Management

Internal data and platform teams deploy MCP servers to democratize access to complex systems.

- **Customer Support Empowerment**: Care agents use MCP-connected GraphQL gateways to answer queries like **"How many participants were in booking #123?"** or **"Have there been previous refunds?"** without navigating multiple dashboards.
- **Non-Developer Data Aggregation**: In industries like **NatCat modeling** (earthquake/flood risk), non-engineers use AI clients to aggregate data from disparate API services efficiently.

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- **Internal Documentation Q&A**: Hosted MCP servers provide RAG-like access to internal wikis, runbooks, and support portals, compressing multi-hour search tasks into single prompts.

3. Regulated Industries (Finance & Healthcare)

MCP servers in these sectors prioritize **audit trails**, **access control**, and **compliance**.

- **Banking & Fraud Detection**:

- **PayPal** and **Raiffeisen Bank** use MCP for real-time transaction processing and risk assessment (40% improvement in risk scoring).

- AI agents correlate **KYC**, **AML**, and behavioral signals across systems to detect suspicious patterns, reducing false positives by **30%**.

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- Compliance servers (e.g., **IBM OpenPages**, **ComplyAI**) enable agents to generate audit evidence for **SOC 2**, **DORA**, and **MiCA** regulations.
- **Healthcare & Diagnostics**:
 - **Mayo Clinic** achieved a **90% reduction in false positives** for cancer diagnosis using MCP-powered image analysis.
 - Servers connect to **Epic Systems** and **Oracle Health** to retrieve patient histories, draft clinical notes from structured EHR data, and match patients to trial criteria.
 - **UCSF** used MCP to analyze genomic datasets, discovering new therapeutic targets for Alzheimer's and cancer.

4. Agentic Workflow Automation

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MCP enables ****multi-step, multi-server orchestration**** where agents plan and execute complex tasks autonomously.

- ****Sales & Marketing Automation****:

- An ****analytics agent**** queries Dremio for customers with declining engagement.

- A ****messaging agent**** receives the list and triggers a ****SendGrid/Twilio MCP server**** for email/SMS campaigns.

- A ****CRM agent**** updates Salesforce or HubSpot records with outreach status.

- ****SEO & Content Operations****:

- Agencies use ****Ahrefs****, ****Semrush****, and ****Google Search Console MCP servers**** to perform technical audits, cluster keywords, and monitor AI search visibility without manual CSV exports.

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- Workflows compress multi-hour audits into single prompts like `"Audit all pages with decayed traffic and suggest fixes."`
- **Financial Planning**: AI agents discover transaction histories, combine them with external risk feeds, and assess creditworthiness against internal policies.

5. Specialized Domain Tools

Niche MCP servers serve specific professional communities:

- **SEO**: Servers for **Ahrefs**, **Semrush**, **DataForSEO**, and **Screaming Frog** enable natural-language queries like `"Show me all 404s with backlinks."`
- **Travel & Lifestyle**: **Google Flights**, **Kayak**, **Surfliner** (wave forecasts), and

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ESPN Fantasy (player stats) servers allow AI to plan trips or optimize fantasy lineups.

- **Infrastructure & DevOps**: **Terraform**, **Kubernetes**, **Prometheus**, and **PagerDuty** servers help platform engineers provision compliant infrastructure, investigate incidents, and optimize cloud costs via chat.

Emerging Trends (2026)

- **Hosted MCP Servers**: One-click cloud deployments (e.g., via **MCP Playground**) are replacing self-hosted stdio servers for remote team collaboration.

- **MCP Gateways**: Regulated enterprises adopt gateways like **Bifrost** to centralize authentication, audit logging, and policy

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enforcement across all MCP traffic.

- **No-Code Agent Building**: **70%** of frontend engineers at some firms now build features without writing code, using MCP-connected agents to convert Figma designs directly to UI components with **75%** first-generation accuracy.

Top Sites to Download MCP Servers

There is no single "download" button for MCP servers; instead, you **install** them via package managers (like ``npx`` or ``pip``) or clone them from **GitHub**. The ecosystem is distributed across several key registries and repositories.

1. Primary Registries & Directories

These sites act as search engines where you can

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discover servers and find their specific installation commands.

[Glama.ai] (<https://glama.ai/mcp/servers>):

The largest directory with **21,000+** servers.

Best for browsing by category (e.g., "Database," "Social Media").

[Smithery.ai] (<https://smithery.ai>): Features

7,000+ servers with a focus on **one-click**

installation for clients like Claude Desktop and Cursor.

[MCP.so] (<https://mcp.so>): A massive

community-driven index with **19,700+** servers,

often hosting the latest unofficial or experimental tools.

[Official

Registry] (<https://registry.modelcontextprotocol>

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.io)**: The canonical, Anthropic-maintained list of verified servers. Best for finding stable, production-ready tools.

* **[PulseMCP](https://pulsemcp.com)**: A curated directory with **11,800+** hand-reviewed servers, useful for filtering out low-quality or abandoned projects.

2. Official Source Code Repositories

For developers who want to inspect code or self-host, **GitHub** is the primary source.

*

[modelcontextprotocol/servers](https://github.com/modelcontextprotocol/servers): The official repository containing reference implementations for core tools (Filesystem, Git,

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PostgreSQL, Brave Search).

*

[punkpeye/awesome-mcp-servers](https://github.com/punkpeye/awesome-mcp-servers): The canonical "Awesome List" on GitHub, curating high-quality community servers.

*

[MCPJam/inspector](https://github.com/MCPJam/inspector): The source for the popular MCP Inspector debugging tool.

Essential Tools for Installation & Testing

To run these servers, you need the following core tools installed on your machine:

1. FastMCP (Python Framework)

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The standard library for building and running Python-based MCP servers.

*****Install Command**:**

```
```bash
```

```
Recommended (using uv)
```

```
uv pip install fastmcp
```

```
Alternative (using pip)
```

```
pip install fastmcp
```

```
```
```

*****Usage**:** Allows you to run local servers instantly with `fastmcp run server.py`.

2. MCP Inspector (Debugging Tool)

A visual interface to test server connections, view JSON-RPC logs, and debug tools before connecting them to an AI agent.

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**** Install Options**:**

**** Homebrew (macOS)**:** ``brew install mcp-inspector``

**** NPX (Node.js)**:** ``npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector@latest``

**** Web**:** Use the hosted version at ****[app.mcpjam.com] (https://app.mcpjam.com)**** (no install required).

**** VS Code**:** Install the ****"MCP Inspector (Beta)"**** extension from the marketplace.

3. Package Managers (Runtime)

Most servers are distributed as packages you run on-demand:

**** Node.js / npx**:** Used for JavaScript/TypeScript servers (e.g., ``npx -y @modelcontextprotocol/server-github``).

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uv / pip: Used for Python servers (e.g., `uv run mcp-server-brave-search``).

Docker: Many enterprise servers are available as container images for secure, isolated deployment.

Quick Start: Installing Your First Server

To install the official **GitHub MCP Server** (allows AI to read your repos):

1. Ensure **Node.js** is installed.
2. Run the following command in your terminal to test it via the Inspector:

```
`` bash
```

```
npx -y @modelcontextprotocol/server-github
```

```
...
```


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3. Or, add it to your **Claude Desktop** config

(`claude\_desktop\_config.json`):

```
```json
{
 "mcpServers": {
 "github": {
 "command": "npx",
 "args": ["-y",
"@modelcontextprotocol/server-github"],
 "env": {
 "GITHUB_PERSONAL_ACCESS_TOKEN":
"ghp_YOUR_TOKEN_HERE"
 }
 }
 }
}
```

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Yes, there are several excellent **free and paid learning sites** for mastering the Model Context Protocol (MCP), ranging from official documentation to interactive courses.

## **## Official & Free Learning Resources**

### **### 1. Anthropic Academy (Official)**

The canonical source for MCP learning, directly from the protocol creators.

- **Courses**: Offers **"Introduction to Model Context Protocol"** and **"MCP: Advanced Topics"**.
- **Format**: Self-paced video modules with Python-focused examples.
- **Cost**: **Free**.
- **Best For**: Developers wanting the

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authoritative reference and production patterns.

- **Link**: [Anthropic Skilljar] (<https://anthropic.skilljar.com>)

## ### 2. Hugging Face MCP Course

A comprehensive, vendor-neutral course built in partnership with Anthropic.

- **Content**: Covers theory, SDKs (Python/TypeScript), and deployment. Includes **4 units** plus a bonus project.
- **Certification**: Offers a **free certificate** upon completion.
- **Cost**: **Free**.
- **Best For**: Learners who want a structured path with exercises and a credential.
- **Link**: [Hugging Face MCP Course] (<https://huggingface.co/learn/mcp>)

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-course)

### ### 3. Microsoft "MCP for Beginners"

A massive open-source curriculum on GitHub covering multiple languages.

- **Languages**: C#, Java, JavaScript, Python, TypeScript, and Rust.
- **Structure**: **11 modules** with 50+ lessons.
- **Cost**: **Free** (MIT License).
- **Best For**: Polyglot developers or those working in the .NET/Java ecosystems.
- **Link**: [GitHub Repository](<https://github.com/microsoft/mcp-for-beginners>)

### ### 4. DeepLearning.AI Short Course

A concise, high-level overview taught by an

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Anthropic instructor.

- **Duration**: ~1 hour 48 minutes (11 lessons).
- **Focus**: Building rich-context AI apps quickly.
- **Cost**: **Free** (during beta/promotional periods).
- **Best For**: A rapid "one-sitting" introduction before diving deeper.
- **Link**: [DeepLearning.AI MCP Course] (<https://www.deeplearning.ai/short-courses/mcp-build-rich-context-ai-apps-with-anthropic>)

## ## Interactive & Paid Platforms

### ### 5. Scrimba (Interactive)

Hands-on, interactive coding courses where you edit code directly in the video.

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- **Top Course**: **"Intro to Model Context Protocol"** (37 mins) and **"The AI Engineer Path"** (11.4 hours).
- **Format**: Interactive screencasts (TypeScript/Node.js focus).
- **Cost**: Requires **Pro subscription** (~\$24.50/mo), but offers a free trial.
- **Best For**: Web developers who learn by doing and want to build a server in under an hour.
- **Link**: [Scrimba MCP Courses] (<https://scrimba.com>)

### ### 6. Udemy (Comprehensive Bootcamps)

Marketplace for deep-dive bootcamps, often on sale for ~\$15–\$20.

- **Top Picks**:
- **"MCP Crash Course: Complete Model Context**

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Protocol in a Day" by Eden Marco (8.5 hours).

- "Complete MCP Developer Guide: Agents, Servers & Tools" (6.5 hours).
- **Cost**: Paid (one-time purchase).
- **Best For**: Structured, long-form learning with lifetime access and certificates.
- **Link**: [Udemy MCP Courses] (<https://www.udemy.com>)

## ## Quick Comparison

If you want...	Start with...	Cost
----------------	---------------	------

:---	:---	:---
------	------	------

<b>The Official Source</b>	Anthropic Academy	Free
----------------------------	-------------------	------

<b>A Certificate</b>	Hugging Face	Free
----------------------	--------------	------

<b>Multi-Language Support</b>	Microsoft GitHub	Free
-------------------------------	------------------	------

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I **Interactive Coding** | Scrimba | Paid (Sub) |

I **Deep Dive Bootcamp** | Udemy | Paid (~\$20) |

I **Quick Overview** | DeepLearning.AI | Free |

Yes, there are **mobile apps** and **mobile-focused MCP servers** available as of August 2026, though their capabilities differ significantly from desktop implementations.

## **## 1. Official Mobile Client Support (Claude Mobile)**

The **Claude mobile app** (iOS and Android) now supports **remote MCP servers**, allowing you to access your configured tools on the go.

**Status**: Available since July 2025 for paid plan



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users.

**\*\*\*Limitation\*\***: You **\*\*cannot configure\*\*** new servers directly in the mobile app. You must add remote MCP URLs via the **\*\*Claude.ai website\*\*** (Settings → Connectors), which then sync to your mobile device.

**\*\*\*Functionality\*\***: Supports tools, prompts, and resources from remote servers only (no local `studio` execution).

## **## 2. Third-Party MCP Client Apps**

Several independent developers have released dedicated MCP client apps for mobile management:

**\*\*\*Systemprompt MCP Client\*\*** (iOS & Android):

**\*\*\*Features\*\***: Voice-controlled interface to

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manage and trigger MCP servers remotely.

Supports secure authentication and multi-server orchestration.

**\* \*\*Availability\*\*:** Free on [App Store] (<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/systemprompt-mcp-client/id6746670168>) and [Google Play] (<https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.systemprompt.mcp>).

**\* \*\*MCP Client\*\*** (iOS only):

**\* \*\*Features\*\*:** Syncs AI tasks from desktop agents (Claude, Cursor) to mobile for tracking and management.

**\* \*\*Availability\*\*:** Free on [App Store] (<https://apps.apple.com/us/app/mcp-client/id6746345658>).

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## ## 3. Mobile Automation Servers (Control Your Phone via AI)

You can install MCP servers *\*on your computer\** that allow AI agents to *\*\*control your physical mobile devices\*\** (Android/iOS) for testing and automation:

*\*\*\*Mobile Next ( `@mobilenext/mobile-mcp` )\*\**:

*\*\*\*Function\*\**: Controls real Android/iOS devices, simulators, and emulators.

*\*\*\*Capabilities\*\**: Tap, swipe, type, take screenshots, read UI trees, and install apps via natural language.

*\*\*\*Install\*\**: `npx -y  
@mobilenext/mobile-mcp@latest`

*\*\*\*Claude Mobile ( `claude-in-mobile` )\*\**:

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**Function**: Unified API for Android (ADB) and iOS Simulator automation.

**Install**: ``npx -y claude-in-mobile`` or via Homebrew (``brew install claude-in-mobile``).

**MobilePixel MCP**:

**Function**: Focused on AI-powered mobile testing with 20+ free tools based on Appium.

**Install**: ``npx -y @mobilepixel/mcp@latest``

## **## 4. Development SDKs for Building Mobile MCP Apps**

If you want to **build** an Android app that **hosts** an MCP server:

**Android MCP SDK**: A Kotlin library that enables Android applications to host full MCP servers

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(tools, resources, prompts) using WebSocket or HTTP/SSE transport.

**Repo**:

[kaeawc/android-mcp-sdk] (<https://github.com/kaeawc/android-mcp-sdk>)

**SAP MDK MCP Server**: Specialized server for SAP Mobile Development Kit, turning AI agents into MDK experts.

**Install**: ``npm install -g @sap/mdk-mcp-server``

## ## Coding an MCP Server: Quick Start Guide

To code an MCP server, you primarily use **TypeScript** (official SDK) or **Python** (FastMCP). Below are the essential steps, boilerplates, and tools.

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## ### 1. Choose Your Stack & Boilerplate

### **\*\*Option A: TypeScript (Official SDK)\*\***

Best for production servers and full control over the protocol.

#### **\* \*\*Boilerplate\*\*:**

[ `aashari/boilerplate-mcp-server` ](<https://github.com/aashari/boilerplate-mcp-server>)

(Production-ready, includes HTTP/STDIO).

#### **\* \*\*Quick Start\*\*:**

```
```bash
git clone
https://github.com/aashari/boilerplate-mcp
-server.git
cd boilerplate-mcp-server
npm install
npm run mcp:stdio # Runs locally
```

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...

Core Logic: Uses

`@modelcontextprotocol/sdk` and `zod` for schema validation.

Option B: Python (FastMCP)

Best for rapid prototyping and data science workflows.

Boilerplate:

[`boffti/mcp\_boilerplate`](https://github.com/boffti/mcp_boilerplate) (FastMCP v2, includes testing).

Quick Start:

```
```bash
```

```
Recommended: use uv
```

```
uv init my-mcp-server
```

```
cd my-mcp-server
```

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```
uv add fastmcp
...
```

**Core Logic**: Uses decorators (`@mcp.tool()`) to define functions instantly.

## ### 2. Essential IDEs & Extensions

To code effectively, use an IDE that supports MCP natively or via extensions:

IDE / Client	Best For	MCP Feature
--------------	----------	-------------

:---	:---	:---
------	------	------

<b>Cursor</b>	<b>Top Pick</b> for AI Coding	Native MCP UI, visual server setup, multi-agent support.
---------------	-------------------------------	----------------------------------------------------------

<b>VS Code</b>	Custom Workflows	Use <b>Cline</b> or <b>Continue</b> extensions for MCP marketplace access.
----------------	------------------	----------------------------------------------------------------------------



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I **Windsurf** | Multi-Agent Flows | Built-in plugin discovery and parallel agent sessions. |

I **Claude Desktop** | Chat-Based Dev | Reference implementation; config via JSON file. |

### ### 3. Debugging Your Server

Never guess—use the **MCP Inspector** to visualize JSON-RPC traffic.

**Tool**: **MCP Inspector** (Official CLI & UI).

**How to Run**:

```
```bash
```

```
# For a local TypeScript server
```

```
npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector node dist/index.js
```

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For a local Python server

```
npx @modelcontextprotocol/inspector uv run  
python server.py  
...
```

Workflow:

1. Launch the Inspector (opens a browser UI).
2. Click **"Connect"** to handshake with your server.
3. Manually trigger **Tools**, **Resources**, or **Prompts** to verify schemas and outputs before connecting to an AI agent.

4. Minimal Code Example (TypeScript)

Here is the absolute minimum code to create a working server with one tool:

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```
` ``typescript
import { McpServer } from
"@modelcontextprotocol/sdk/server/mcp.js";
import { StdioServerTransport } from
"@modelcontextprotocol/sdk/server/stdio.js";
import { z } from "zod";

const server = new McpServer({ name:
"demo-server", version: "1.0.0" });

// Define a tool
server.tool(
  "add",
  "Add two numbers",
  { a: z.number(), b: z.number() },
  async ({ a, b }) => ({
    content: [{ type: "text", text: `Result: ${a + b}` }],
```

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```
})
```

```
);
```

```
// Start server
```

```
const transport = new StdioServerTransport();
```

```
server.connect(transport);
```

```
...
```

In the MCP ecosystem, a **Plugin** is a **distribution bundle** that packages one or more MCP servers, skills, and slash commands into a single, installable unit. While an **MCP Server** is the technical backend code, a **Plugin** is the **product** users actually install from a marketplace.

Key Differences: Plugin vs. MCP Server

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I Feature I **MCP Server** I **Plugin** I

I :--- I :--- I :--- I

I **Definition** I A single process exposing tools via JSON-RPC. I A **bundle** containing MCP servers + configuration + skills. I

I **Analogy** I The engine (technical component). I The car (complete product with engine + interior + wheels). I

I **Scope** I Connects to **one** specific system (e.g., PostgreSQL). I Solves a **workflow** (e.g., "Full GitHub Workflow" includes PRs, Issues, and Code Review skills). I

I **Installation** I Manual config (`mcp.json`) or CLI. I One-click install from a **Marketplace**. I

I **Portability** I Requires manual setup on each machine. I Syncs settings, auth, and tools across teams/devices. I

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How Plugins Work

A plugin acts as a wrapper that simplifies the complexity of raw MCP servers:

1. **Bundling**: It groups related servers (e.g., a "Database Plugin" might bundle PostgreSQL, Redis, and Mongo servers).
2. **Configuration**: It pre-defines environment variables, auth flows (OAuth), and tool permissions.
3. **Skills**: It often includes custom **Skills** (prompt templates) to teach the AI how to best use the bundled tools.

Where to Find & Install Plugins

Unlike raw servers found on GitHub, plugins are

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hosted in curated marketplaces integrated directly into AI clients:

Claude Code Marketplace: Accessed via `claude plugin search` in the CLI or the "Extensions" tab in the UI.

Cursor Extensions: Found in the **Extensions Sidebar** (similar to VS Code), allowing one-click activation of MCP bundles.

Windsurf Cascade Store: A curated list of "Flows" and plugins optimized for the Cascade agent.

Smithery & Glama: Web-based directories that offer "One-Click Connect" buttons to install plugins into your local client.

Example: GitHub Plugin vs. GitHub MCP Server

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****Raw MCP Server****: You install

`@modelcontextprotocol/server-github`. You must manually set the `GITHUB\_TOKEN` in your config file. It gives you raw tools like `list\_issues` and `create\_pull\_request`.

****GitHub Plugin****: You click "Install GitHub" in the marketplace. It automatically handles OAuth login, bundles the MCP server, adds a `/review-pr` skill, and configures rate limiting policies out of the box.

Best Practices for MCP Servers

Building production-ready MCP servers requires strict adherence to security, design, and resilience patterns. As of August 2026, the ecosystem has standardized around specific principles to prevent token bloat, security vulnerabilities, and agent

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failures.

1. Security & Authentication (Mandatory)

Security is the highest priority, with **OAuth 2.1** now mandatory for all remote servers.

Implement OAuth 2.1 with PKCE: Never rely on network isolation alone. Use **PKCE (Proof Key for Code Exchange)** and validate the `code_challenge_method` on every request.

Validate Audience Claims: Ensure tokens are minted specifically for your server using **RFC 8707 (Resource Indicators)**. Reject tokens with mismatched `aud` claims to prevent "confused deputy" attacks.

Least Privilege & Scoping: Enforce per-tool

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scopes. A tool that reads data should never have write permissions. Use ****On-Behalf-Of (OBO)**** authentication so agents act with the user's exact permissions, not admin credentials.

*** **No Token Passthrough****: Never forward a client's access token to upstream APIs. Instead, exchange it for a service-specific token with limited scope.

*** **Bind to Localhost Only****: For local development, bind strictly to `127.0.0.1` or `::1`. Never use `0.0.0.0`, which exposes the server to the local network.

2. Tool Schema Design (Optimization)

Schema design directly impacts agent accuracy and cost. A poorly designed schema can waste

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****50,000+ tokens**** before a single task is executed.

*** **Naming Convention**:** Use ****`verb\_object`**** (snake_case) or ****`verbObject`**** (camelCase) consistently. Examples: **`create\_ticket`**, **`query\_database`**. Avoid mixing styles.

*** **Description Economy**:** Keep descriptions between ****200–400 characters****. Include ****what**** it does and ****when**** to use it, but omit obvious parameter details already defined in the schema.

*** **Flatten Input Schemas**:** Avoid deep nesting. Complex objects increase token count and LLM cognitive load. Decompose nested fields into flat arguments or split the tool into multiple specific tools.

*** **Use Tool Annotations**:** Explicitly set

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`readOnlyHint: true` for search/get tools and
`destructiveHint: true` for write/delete actions.

Missing annotations cause ****30% of marketplace rejections**** and break client safety features.

****Return Errors in Result****: Do not throw protocol-level errors for business logic failures. Return a structured `success: false` object with a `suggestion` field to guide the agent's retry logic.

3. Error Handling & Resilience

Robust servers guide the AI on how to recover from failures rather than crashing.

****Retry Guidance****: For transient errors (timeouts, 429 Rate Limit, 503 Service Unavailable), return a structured error with

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`retry\_after\_seconds` and `max\_attempts`. Do not retry client errors (400, 403, 404).

Exponential Backoff: Implement server-side backoff for external dependencies. Use a multiplier (e.g., 2x) with a cap (e.g., 30 seconds) to prevent thundering herds.

Circuit Breakers: If an external API fails repeatedly, trip a circuit breaker to fail fast and save tokens, rather than waiting for timeouts on every request.

Human-in-the-Loop: For destructive actions (e.g., `delete\_database`, `send\_email`), require explicit user confirmation via the **Elicitation** primitive before execution.

MCP Skills & Prompt Engineering

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****Skills**** in the MCP context refer to bundled capabilities—often combining ****Prompts****, ****Tools****, and ****Frameworks****—that teach the AI how to solve specific domain problems.

1. Designing Effective MCP Prompts

Prompts are reusable templates that standardize complex workflows.

*** **Parameterize Everything**:** Define clear ``argsSchema`` for your prompts. Example: A ``code_review`` prompt should accept ``target_path`` and ``focus_areas`` (security, performance) as arguments.

*** **Embed Resources**:** Use prompts to automatically fetch and inject relevant context

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(e.g., documentation, logs) via **Resource URIs** before the AI generates a response.

Chainable Workflows: Design prompts to output structured data that can be piped into subsequent tools. Example: A `summarize_issues` prompt outputs a list of IDs that a `close_issues` tool can then consume.

2. Advanced Skill Patterns

Gates & Validation: Implement "Gates" (`::`) as validation criteria. The AI checks its own output against these rules (e.g., "cite sources," "run tests") before presenting the final result.

Reasoning Frameworks: Bundle specific reasoning frameworks (e.g., `@ReACT`, `@5W1H`) with your tools to guide the agent's thought

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process for complex tasks.

*****Style Modifiers****: Use style tags (e.g.,
`#concise`, `#analytical`) to allow users to toggle
the tone and format of the output dynamically.

3. Example: "Code Review" Skill Structure

A complete skill bundles the prompt, tools, and
validation:

1. ****Prompt****: `>>code_review target:'src/'
focus:'security'`
2. ****Tools Used****: `list\_files`, `read\_file`,
`search\_vulnerabilities`.
3. ****Gate****: `:: verify:"npm audit"` (The AI must run
this command and pass before finishing).
4. ****Output****: A structured report with severity

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levels and fix suggestions.

Top Suggestions & Advice for MCP Success (2026)

Based on current production data and common failure modes, here are the most critical recommendations for building and deploying MCP servers.

1. Critical "Do Nots" (Avoid These Common Mistakes)

****Never Print to `stdout`****

The **#1** cause of immediate server crashes is printing debug logs, `print()` statements, or `console.log()` to standard output.

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Why: MCP uses ``stdout`` exclusively for JSON-RPC messages. Any extra text corrupts the protocol stream.

Fix: Route **all** diagnostics, logs, and debug output to ``stderr``.

Avoid Vague Tool Descriptions

AI agents rely entirely on your descriptions to decide when to call a tool.

Mistake: Descriptions like "Gets data" or "Updates the system."

Fix: Write 200–400 character descriptions that explicitly state **what** the tool does, **when** to use it, and **what** specific parameters are needed (e.g., "Retrieves current weather for a specific city. Use when the user asks for temperature or forecast. Requires 'city'").

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parameter.").

****Don't Block the Event Loop****

Synchronous I/O (e.g., waiting for a database query without ``await``) freezes the entire server, causing timeouts for all other tools.

*** **Fix**:** Use ``async/await`` patterns and connection pooling for all external calls (DBs, APIs, file systems).

2. Security Hardening Checklist

****Implement OAuth 2.1 with PKCE****

Hardcoded API keys and basic auth are deprecated and unsafe for remote servers.

*** **Action**:** Enforce ****OAuth 2.1**** with ****PKCE**** (Proof Key for Code Exchange) for all remote HTTP

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connections. Validate `aud` (audience) claims to prevent "confused deputy" attacks.

****Bind to Localhost Only****

A common vulnerability is binding local development servers to `0.0.0.0`, exposing them to the entire local network.

*****Action****: Explicitly bind to `127.0.0.1` or `::1`.
Never use `0.0.0.0` unless behind a strict firewall and authentication gateway.

****Validate Input Schemas Strictly****

Garbage inputs from hallucinating agents can crash servers or trigger unintended actions.

*****Action****: Use validation libraries (e.g.,
****Pydantic**** for Python, ****Zod**** for TypeScript) to enforce strict types and constraints on every tool

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input before execution.

3. Performance & Reliability Tips

****Cache Aggressively****

Repeated reads (e.g., fetching the same documentation or file) are the biggest latency killer.

****Advice****: Implement in-memory caching for read-only resources. Cache tool results for a short TTL (Time-To-Live) to reduce redundant API calls.

****Handle Errors Gracefully****

Do not let exceptions crash the server or leak raw stack traces to the AI.

****Advice****: Wrap every tool in a `try/catch` block. Return structured JSON errors with a `suggestion` field (e.g., "Retry in 30 seconds") to guide the

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agent's recovery logic.

****Use Absolute Paths****

Relative paths in configuration files are the leading cause of "spawn ENOENT" errors, especially when launched from GUI apps (like Cursor or Claude Desktop) which have different working directories than terminals.

****Advice****: Always use absolute paths for commands and file resources in your ``mcp.json`` config.

4. Workflow Design Patterns

****Start with the "Inspector"****

Never debug directly in your AI chat client.

****Advice****: Use the ****MCP Inspector**** (``npx`

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@modelcontextprotocol/inspector`) to test connections, list tools, and invoke calls manually. If it fails in the Inspector, it will fail in your AI client.

****Design for "Human-in-the-Loop"****

For destructive actions (delete, send email, deploy code), do not rely solely on the AI's judgment.

****Advice****: Use the ****Elicitation**** primitive to force a user confirmation dialog before executing high-risk tools.

****Keep Schemas Lean****

Verbose JSON schemas waste tokens on every request, increasing cost and latency.

****Advice****: Flatten nested objects, remove redundant descriptions, and split massive tools into smaller, focused ones.